

Tribals and TRIBULATIONS

The Left Front's inability to contain Maoist violence in Lalgarh threatens its decades-long grip on power

| By Elora Sen |

West Bengal's tryst with violence seems to have assumed a never-ending character. The shadows of Nandigram haunted the Left Front in the Lok Sabha elections and were reflected in its poor showing. But now it faces a bigger challenge—the blood-bath unleashed by tribals in Lalgarh. The tribal belt in West Midnapore district came into focus ever since Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya's convoy was attacked near Salboni last November. The police atrocities that followed made way for local residents to come together behind the Chattaradhar Mahato-led People's Committee Against Police Atrocities (PCAPA).

The state Government has been unable to contain violence for the past six months. Bikash, a Maoist leader, and his followers have enforced their control over the area. Such is the public support enjoyed by them that even the planned action by Central forces has been postponed. The state had asked for 50 units of Central Forces and the elite anti-Maoist Forces—Cobra and Greyhound. But only 16 units have been sanctioned and the Cobra force is yet to reach. Even though strategists claim that it is too late, Bhattacharya has said that the Maoists must be contained and surrounded, but not attacked directly unless they attack first.

As of now, more than 100 trained Maoists are now in Jangalmahal. They are also believed to have trained the local youth. Such is their grip of the area that even the dead body of Shaflu Soren, a CPI(M) worker who was

allegedly shot dead by Maoists, was not allowed to be removed from its place for six days. That's not all. In a recent incident, tribals set ablaze CPI(M) party offices in Lalgarh and Belatikri and dug up roads leading to Lalgarh from Dharampur, Goaltore and Pirakata to prevent Central forces from entering. Even the recent Lok Sabha polls could take place only when the state Government gave in to the PCAPA demand that the polling booth be set away from Lalgarh and that no state police be allowed to look after security. If all this wasn't enough, the Maoists have also issued a death sentence in the chief minister's name.

A state of complete lawlessness prevails in Lalgarh with police camps being removed from Dharampur and Ramgarh. CPI(M) workers have been killed and police stations and party offices have been set on fire despite Section 144 being in force. Lending a political angle to the crisis, the CPI(M) politburo issued a statement, saying, "The Maoists are using poor tribals as human shields to further their goals. Shockingly, these depredations have the direct and indirect support of important sections of the opposition parties in West Bengal."

Mahato, however, had always maintained that his outfit does not have Maoist links but is a platform for the tribals who launched this agitation spontaneously. He added that the "peaceful agitation" against the CPI(M) would continue. At least four police camps have been withdrawn from the area which has seen clashes between

